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RAIL TALES FROM INDEPENDENT INDIA

Railway Regroupings and the Secret of the Rajdhani

Newly independent India and its railways were a different story as compared to the pre-Partition years. The divided and uprooted railway lines needed consolidation and the first and foremost thing that happened post-Independence (though it had been in the works for quite some time) was the regrouping of the railway system. Prior to Independence, at the last count, there were as many as forty-two independent railway systems in the country, both big and small. [128] Once regrouped, the systems were streamlined and made more efficient. Among the several other developments over the years including the merging of private railway companies which were then taken over by the state, I have recalled a select few, not based on merit or importance but stories that are interesting, and sometimes little-known ones, since this is neither a history book nor a detailed story of the Indian Railways.

REGROUPING INDIA'S RAILWAYS

After Independence, it was time for consolidating the country's railway system. To increase the efficiency of the railways, in 1951–52 the Government of India regrouped the entire railway network into six railway zones. Later, from 1955 to 1966, three more zones were added. [129]

The regroupings began with the south zone on 14 April 1951 and ended with the eastern zone on 14 April 1952. [130]